

Imaging: Nikhil Wahal

There's a particular kind of madness that grips India between Navratri and New Year. Phones buzz with countdown timers, carts fill faster than we can think, and "only 2 left at this price" does more persuading than any salesperson ever could. Somewhere inside that noise, a second economy is having its best quarter too. Fraudsters don't improvise during the festive season. They plan for it. Lookalike storefronts go up weeks in advance, AI spins up hundreds of them in a weekend, cloned voices call pretending to be your bank, and a harmless-looking APK quietly asks for permissions it has no business having. The bait is always the same: a discount too good to pass up, and too little time to think about it.

So we asked the people who watch these attacks for a living what's changed this year, who's being targeted, and what you should do before you tap "Buy Now".